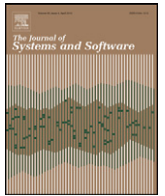




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Controversy corner

Disciplined and free-spirited: ‘Time-out behaviour’ at the Agile conference[☆]

Orit Hazzan^{*}, Uri Leron

Department of Education in Technology and Science, Technion – Israel Institute of Technology, Israel

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ABSTRACT

In this article we observe and try to understand a peculiar duality in the agile community, whereby on the one hand, we see a serious professional community working hard to improve the quality of software products and submitting to the strictest discipline of high professional standards, while on the other hand, in its conferences, we see the same community adopting a playful free-spirited stance. Invoking an anthropological perspective, we propose that both the serious professional aspects and the playful free-spirited atmosphere at the conference, as well as the connection between the two, can all be seen to emerge from the fundamental principles of the agile community as expressed by its Manifesto.

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Observing the agile software development community, one may notice a peculiar duality.

On the one hand, agile software development is serious business... Agile software development is widely acknowledged today as a mainstream software development methodology, and agile-driven software projects are managed in a disciplined manner and achieve impressive results (cf. e.g., the VersionOne 2008 *State of Agile Development Survey*¹). Specifically, testing gets top priority, the customer is in an ongoing interaction with the development team, and measures and time estimations are set, gathered, analyzed and acted upon.

...but, on the other hand, its conferences, in addition to dealing with the usual serious professional matters, are distinguished by their playful and free-spirited character: To an outside observer taking a quick glance at the Agile conference – the biggest annual event of the agile community – the conference might appear more like a playful party than one dealing with such serious professional mat-

ters. She would notice, for example, that the conference is organized around a central metaphor of the performing arts, including stages, ad-hoc musical bands and producers, and that most of the sessions are interactive and reflective, and include role playing, group work, and games. In addition, she would observe that roughly half the sessions are about human aspects (leadership, culture, coaching and the like), not about technical issues. In fact, many titles may seem hardly related to software engineering, as the following small sample from the Agile 2008 and 2009 conferences² shows:

Fashion Cycle
Scaling Agile: Finding Your Agile Tribe
Agility, Evolution, Emergence, and the Primordial Ooze
Ancient Philosophers and Blowhard Jamborees
“We Suck Less!” Isn’t Mediocrity Great?
Mirror, Mirror on the Wall... Why Me?
Storytelling Skills for Agile Teams
Big Ball of Mud
Effective Pairing: The Good, the Bad, and the Ugly
You Say Tomato, I Say Pomodoro
Help Me to See... Corporate Culture
Coach Aikido: Lessons and Support for Abused Coaches in Hostile Environments
The Orge and The Wimp: Clever Influencing Tricks – Help the Most Reluctant Teams
Agility Night Live – TV Sketches and Project Stories

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These articles will succeed only to the extent that they stimulate not just thought, but action. If you have a strong reaction to the article that follows, either positive or negative, send it along to your editor, at card@software.org. We will publish the best of the responses as CONTROVERSY REVISITED.

^{*} Corresponding author.

E-mail address: oritha@technion.ac.il (O. Hazzan).

¹ “State of Agile Development” Survey: <http://www.versionone.com/whitepapers.asp#survey>.

² See the Agile 2008 and the 2009 conferences websites at: <http://www.agile2008.org/> and <http://agile2009.agilealliance.org/>.

In this short article we – as members of the agile community – temporarily adopt an outsider view of the community in an attempt to understand the above duality of *disciplined free spirit*. We propose that both the serious professional aspects and the playful free-spirited atmosphere at the conference, as well as the connection between the two, can all be seen to emerge from the fundamental principles of the agile community as expressed by its Manifesto.³

While it is quite clear how the serious professional behaviour of the agile community stems from the Agile Manifesto, we claim that the playful free-spirited atmosphere at the conference also reflects the same principles. Indeed, applying in daily practice the Manifesto principles that deal with social aspects of agile software development is not easy, due to various constraints in the normal life of the organization; the conference, in contrast, is an ideal place for enacting these principles more fully, because it supplies the sort of space where the strict rules of everyday behaviour are relaxed, or replaced by different set of rules. In anthropological terms, Agile conferences could be viewed as offering a *liminal zone*, which according to the Oxford anthropologist Fox (2004, p. 89), is “an equivocal, marginal, borderline state, in which one finds a degree of ‘cultural remission’ – a structured, temporary relaxation or suspension of normal social controls (also known as ‘legitimised deviance’ or ‘time-out behaviour’).” In the rest of the article we examine the ‘disciplined free-spirited duality’ of the agile community from this anthropological perspective.

In her book *Watching the English: The Hidden Rules of English Behaviour*, Fox (2004) emphasizes the importance of pubs in the life of the English people:

It would be impossible even to *attempt* to understand Englishness without spending a lot of time in pubs, and it would almost be possible to achieve a good understanding of Englishness without ever leaving the pubs. (p. 88)

Fox (2004) explains what is it about the *culture* of the pub (i.e., its implicit set of rules and norms) that makes it so central to the life of the English, and we believe that some of her explanations also apply for the culture of the Agile conference. As already hinted above, both institutions fill a need for people to establish a liminal zone, where new rules are set, allowing different behaviour from their constrained everyday environment. The need for a liminal zone, in turn, comes from a need for social *bonding* that these populations – the pub patrons and software engineers – cannot satisfy in their everyday environment; the help of a special environment with special rules and special “props”, which actively promotes and enables such bonding, is needed.⁴

Though on first look, the behaviour at the Agile conference is free and spontaneous, an anthropological perspective would still suggest that it is governed by an elaborate system of tacit rules, or *etiquette*. For example, here is how an anthropologist could describe her observations at the conference:

We tend to think of rules and laws as unpleasant things, imposing limits and restrictions on our behaviour, inhibiting our natural spontaneity and creativity. The very word ‘etiquette’ may evoke an image of stuffy propriety. Yet the unwritten rules governing agile conference behaviour are not restrictive or inhibiting – quite the opposite. Like all other aspects of agile etiquette, they are designed to promote sociability. If anything, they encourage *more* verbal exchanges, *more* com-

munication, than would otherwise occur among the naturally reserved natives.

If this description accords with the spirit of the agile conference as you have experienced it, then it is time to uncover our little trick: this is actually a quote from the book *Passport to the Pub: The Tourist's Guide to Pub Etiquette* (Fox, 1996, p. 36), where we have made only the following two replacements: “agile conference behaviour” instead of “pub-talk” and “agile etiquette” instead of “pub etiquette”.

Our anthropologist would base this observation on data like the following:

- The three buffet meals for the duration of the conference – included in the conference program and fee, and served in a huge hall full with round tables – are effectively designed for maximizing socializing and mingling.
- The Open Jam stage which welcomes the participants to freely “share questions and quandaries, talk to the experts, demonstrate software and techniques, and experiment with emerging Agile practices and ideas”. The rules of this stage are clearly stated: “Sessions don’t need to be formal, like the ones on the program (in fact it’s more fun if they are not). Anyone can convene a session at the Open Jam stage based on a passion and a commitment to make the session happen”.⁵
- The interactive format of most sessions, which includes games and teamwork followed by reflections. For example, at the Agile 2008 conference, in the Culture stage’s session on *Punctuated Continuity: Using Ritual and Ceremony to Avoid Process Fatigue*, the participants were asked to compose Agile Haiku, in order to promote communication and reflection on agile software development in general, and rituals in agile development environments in particular; The goal of *The Agile CTO* session, facilitated in the 2009 conference, was “to gather experienced executives (and people who work closely with them) to discover and document agile patterns for CTOs”.⁶ The *Agile Playground* session in the Agile 2009 conference introduced “five interactive games that a facilitator can add to their toolkit for team and management training.” It is specifically stated in the session description that “All participants will be immersed in the games; there are no observers.”⁷
- The “Programming with the Stars” competition (*a-la* TV’s “Dancing with the Stars”), in which leaders of the community program with newcomers. This framework clearly elicits communication on agile software development processes.

In Fox’s terminology, the interactive format of most sessions is an “excuse to make contact”; after all, why can’t agile software development be discussed without these “props”? Here it is in Fox’s (1996) own words, this time leaving in the original English pub terminology:

The laws of pub etiquette are designed to promote friendly interaction and social bonding. Any form of behaviour which increases the amount of sociable communication between members of the pub-tribe, or strengthens the social bonds that link them together, is encouraged. (p. 56)

We don’t find it easy to initiate friendly conversation with strangers, or to develop closer relationships with fellow pub-goers. We need help. We need props. We need excuses to make

³ The Agile Manifesto Website: <http://agilemanifesto.org/>.

⁴ In the case of the agile community, the need for social bonding is reflected, for example, by the first principle of the Agile Manifesto – *Individuals and interactions over processes and tools*.

⁵ Source: <http://www.agile2009.org/openjam>.

⁶ See the Agile 2009 website at <http://agile2009.agilealliance.org/node/915/>.

⁷ See the Agile 2009 website at <http://agile2009.agilealliance.org/node/2001>.

contact. We need toys and games that get us involved with each other. (p. 64)

So far we have pointed out to some similarity between two social institutions, the agile conference and the English pub. We have also suggested that the similar behaviour actually comes from the same source, namely, the need to create a “liminal zone”, where the normal rules of behaviour are temporarily suspended (or changed), and participants can behave in ways that are not possible under the social norms of daily life or the workplace.

We would like to suggest that, furthermore, the free spirit and playfulness witnessed in the agile conference can in fact be seen to emerge from the very principles of the Agile Manifesto. Specifically, from interviews with twelve of the original seventeen pioneers of the Agile Manifesto (Hazzan et al., 2010), we learn that they were initially mainly concerned with setting principles and rules to ensure software reliability, quality, cost, early delivery and the like. Only later, in the second stage, were they driven to put in center stage human aspects of software development, again, with very clear guides, rules and rituals, such as stand up meetings, role assignment to team members, and ongoing interaction with the customer. Gradually, the importance of human and social aspects of the software development process has emerged, and with it the playful free spirited behaviour in the agile conference.

However, it may be quite difficult to make radical changes in the social environment of everyday development sites, even those in the process of adopting and implementing agile principles. After all, the culture of the software engineering community had been shaped over many years, ever since the early days of the discipline, before teamwork and communication were recognized as essential ingredients in software development. Thus, in reality, though social aspects of the Agile Manifesto may be visible in agile development sites (as in such rituals as stand-up meetings and reflective processes, designed to enhance communication, transparency, trust and social bonding), it is much easier to fully implement these agile principles within the liminal zone of the conference.

What can the above duality offer to software organizations adopting agile software development? What practical implications may be suggested by the foregoing analysis? We propose that the two kinds of behaviour, the disciplined and the free-spirited, roughly correspond to the creative and rigorous stages of development, and are thus complementary and mutually supportive. On the one hand, the free-spirited behaviour – e.g., in the reflection processes, in the ongoing interaction with the customer, and in the transparency that gives each team member access to the project data and time estimations – encourages suggestions for the improvement of the development process, which in many cases help make the development process more disciplined. On the other hand, the disciplined behaviour – e.g., test-driven development and time estimation in hour-resolution – may elicits needs and ideas for how to improve the development process, which in turn can be applied in the reflection session, discussed with the customer, or brought up in the stand up meetings for future discussion. On this view, it would be beneficial for software organizations in their

practice to acknowledge and promote the disciplined/free-spirited duality, and explore how they may be best balanced for improving the development processes.

However, in the spirit of the fourth principle of the Agile Manifesto – Responding to change over following a plan – and based on our considerable experience in introducing agility in software organizations, we note that there is no single optimal balance between discipline and free-spirit and each organization ought to explore and find its own balance. Moreover, the best balance may vary between different teams in different stages of the adoption process, and between different projects. In our practice, for example, we met a team that adopted the disciplined practices of continuous integration and test-driven development (TDD) at the early stages of agile adoption, but expressed resistance for adopting the more free-spirited practice of reflection. On the other hand, another team from the same organization, after a year of introducing agile practices, applied the reflection practice very successfully, but still had difficulties with the more disciplined practice of TDD. Our proposal is, then, that each team and organization choose its own balance of the disciplined/free-spirited duality via an *agile process*, that is, a gradual process where the balance is constantly monitored by agile practices such as reflections, testing and measures.

It seems appropriate to close this short note with a quote from the cover of the first edition of *Extreme Programming Explained – Embrace Change* (Beck, 2000), showing that the first buds of the “disciplined free spirit” were already visible in the early days of the agile movement:

Software development projects can be fun, productive, and even daring. Yet they can consistently deliver value to a business and remain under control.

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- Orit Hazzan** is an associate professor at the Department of Education in Technology and Science of the Technion - Israel Institute of Technology. In addition to about 100 papers Hazzan published in refereed journals and conference proceedings, she is a co-author of two books: *Human Aspects of Software Engineering* (published in 2004 by Charles River Media) and *Agile Software Engineering* (published in 2008 by Springer). In parallel to her research work, she is a consultant for several software projects in the Israeli software industry. She presents her research at computer science and software engineering education conferences, as well as at conferences on software engineering in general and agile software development in particular.
- Uri Leron** is Emeritus of the Churchill Family Chair of Education in Science and Technology at the Technion - Israel Institute of Technology. He had been a ring theorist before switching his research interests to mathematical thinking and learning. He was the recipient of a one-month Residency at the Rockefeller Center in Bellagio, Italy, to study implications of cognitive psychology and evolutionary psychology for mathematical thinking in general, and for understanding the sources of ubiquitous and recurring errors in particular.